Chiara Falco

PhD in Public Economics

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Academic Profile

I am an applied economist specialising in the governance of natural resources, sustainability transitions, and the distributional consequences of public policies and large infrastructure investments. My research combines applied microeconometrics, impact evaluation, and spatial analysis to examine how institutions, governance structures, and policy design shape the social, economic, and environmental outcomes of territorial transformation.

My work is organised around two connected research areas. The first examines the governance of large energy infrastructure and sustainability transitions, studying how hydropower development affects land use, deforestation, rural conflict, and local development trajectories in Brazil, and what these findings reveal about the institutional conditions for equitable and sustainable infrastructure governance. The second investigates the institutional and cultural dimensions of climate adaptation, asking how historical and social structures shape the capacity of rural economies to respond to environmental shocks, with attention to gendered and place-specific outcomes. Across both areas, I integrate individual- and household-level microdata with administrative, geospatial, and historical sources to produce evidence relevant to governance and policy design.

I have led interdisciplinary research projects and coordinated applied collaborations across Europe, Latin America, Southeast Asia, and Sub-Saharan Africa. Alongside research and teaching, I have experience in project management, impact evaluation, and the translation of empirical findings into evidence for public institutions and international organisations. I hold the Italian National Scientific Qualification as Associate Professor in Economic Policy (sector 13/A2).

Academic Positions

Evaluation Specialist (Consultant - Roster)

2026 –

Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO)

Assistant Professor

2023 – 2026

Department of Environmental Science and Policy (ESP), University of Milan, Milan (Italy)

- Research in applied environmental and agricultural economics: climate impacts on agriculture, hydropower infrastructure, land use change, deforestation, trade policy, and rural development.
- Principal Investigator of the 'WATERMAN' sub-project leading the construction of an original dam-level dataset for Brazil enabling causal identification of infrastructure shocks and their socioeconomic and environmental consequences.
- Research Associate, Research Center of Environmental Economics (CEMAR) and Research Center of Public Policy and Religion (CERP), University of São Paulo, Brazil (since 2022).

Research Position

2021 – 2023

Department of Economics (DEMB), University of Modena and Reggio Emilia, Modena (Italy)

- Research project: *The Economics of Culture: Ethnicity, Gender and Their Interactions* (PRIN 2017KHR4MB). PI: Prof. G. Bertocchi.
- Constructed and harmonised a large-scale individual- and household-level microdata panel drawing on multiple waves of the Demographic and Health Surveys (DHS) across Sub-Saharan African countries, covering fertility, family planning, and reproductive health indicators.

- Merged DHS microdata with ethnographic and historical datasets (Murdock's Ethnographic Atlas, D-PLACE) at the individual and cluster level, requiring careful geo-referencing and cross-survey standardisation of variable definitions across countries and survey rounds.
- Performed data cleaning, quality checks, and construction of harmonised indicators (e.g. ideal family size, contraceptive use, child mortality) for cross-country empirical analysis in Stata, hence implementation of econometric techniques.

Post-doctoral Research Fellow 2019 – 2021

Department of Economics (FEA), University of São Paulo, Brazil — CAPES Fellowship, Ministry of Education, Brazil

- Research project: *Climate change and conflict: empirical evidence from Brazil*. PI: Prof. R. Corbi. Investigated the effects of natural disasters on environmental preferences and political attitudes; coordinated social development projects with impact evaluation in the territories of Parelheiros and Grajaú (São Paulo), including children's and youth programmes funded by Projeto Itaú–UNICEF.

Post-doctoral Research Fellow 2017 – 2019

Department of Environmental Science and Policy (ESP), University of Milan, Milan (Italy)

- Research project: *Econometrics of climate change and agriculture*. PI: Prof. V. Raimondi. Analysed the effects of climate variability on agricultural outcomes, migration, and land use; contributed to the EU HORIZON2020 STRENGTH2FOOD project on geographical indication policies and rural areas.

Research Associate 2016 – 2017

Department of Economics, Management and Quantitative Methods, University of Milan, Milan (Italy)

- Research project: *International trade and food quality in the agri-food sector*. PI: Prof. A. Olper. Analysed the impact of EU food quality policies (PDO/PGI) on intra- and extra-EU trade using structural gravity models.

Editorial Experience

Associate Editor — *QOpen* (Development Economics) 2026 –

Oxford University Press

Refereeing Activity

Nature Climate Change · European Review of Agricultural Economics · Journal of Environmental Studies and Sciences · Population and Environment · Bio-based and Applied Economics · Migration and Development · Environment, Development and Sustainability

Education

PhD in Public Economics 2011 – 2015

University of Milano-Bicocca and Università Cattolica del Sacro Cuore, Milan (Italy)

- Dissertation: *Essays on International Migration*.
- Merit-based PhD scholarship funded by the Italian Ministry of Education and the University of Milano-Bicocca.

MSc in Economics 2009 – 2011

University of Milano-Bicocca, Milan (Italy)

- Thesis: *Attitudes towards immigrants: theory and international empirical evidence*.

BSc in Economics and Business 2005 – 2009

University of Milano-Bicocca, Milan (Italy)

- Erasmus Scholarship (2007, EU Project).

Additional Training

- Data Analysis for Social Scientists — Massachusetts Institute of Technology (2025)
- Risks and Policy Responses in Developing Countries — Summer School, University of Milan, Gargnano (2015)
- Analytics and Policy Design of Migration — Winter School, Georgetown University, Qatar (2015)
- Investment, Saving and Wellbeing in Developing Countries — Summer School, University of Milan, Gargnano (2014)
- International Migration — Summer School, Kiel Institute for the World Economy, Kiel, Germany (2014)
- Development Economics — Summer School, London School of Economics and Political Science, London (2010)

Other Qualifications

- Italian National Scientific Qualification (ASN) for Associate Professor — Competition Sector 13/A2 (Economic Policy), 2025

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-reviewed International Journals

- Falco C., Raimondi V. (2026). Hydropower dams, deforestation and land use change: evidence from Brazil. *Ecological Economics* Vol 250, 109148, ISSN 0921-8009. DOI: 10.1016/j.ecolecon.2026.109148
- Falco C., Bartoli A. (2026). Migrants' legal status and exploitation: the case of the Italian agricultural sector. *Review of Agricultural, Food and Environmental Studies* Vol 107, pages 85–112. DOI: 10.1007/s41130-025-00252-1
- Raimondi V., Curzi D., Olper A., Lucarno R., Falco C. (2025). The environmental bias of trade policies in the agri-food sector. *Agricultural Economics*, 00: 1–18. DOI: 10.1111/agec.70054
- Raimondi V., Curzi D., Arfini F., Falco C. (2024). Dynamic and spatial approaches to assess the impact of Geographical Indications on rural areas. *Journal of Rural Studies*, 108, 103279. DOI: 10.1016/j.jrurstud.2024.103279
- Falco C., Corbi R. (2023). Natural disasters and preferences for the environment: evidence from the Impressionable Years. *Economics Letters*, 222, 110946. DOI: 10.1016/j.econlet.2022.110946
- Falco C., Rotondi V., Kong D., Spelta V. (2021). Investment, Insurance and Weather Shocks: Evidence from Cambodia. *Ecological Economics*, 188, 107115. DOI: 10.1016/j.ecolecon.2021.107115
- Raimondi V., Falco C., Curzi D., Olper A. (2020). Trade Effects of Geographical Indication Policy: The EU Case. *Journal of Agricultural Economics*, 71(2), 330–356. DOI: 10.1111/1477-9552.12349
- Falco C., Galeotti M., Olper A. (2019). Climate change and Migration. Is agriculture the main channel? *Global Environmental Change*, 59, 101995. DOI: 10.1016/j.gloenvcha.2019.101995
- Falco C., Donzelli F., Olper A. (2018). Climate Change, Agriculture and Migration: A Survey. *Sustainability*, 10, 1405. DOI: 10.3390/su10051405
- Falco C., Rotondi V. (2016). The less extreme, the more you leave: radical Islam and willingness to migrate. *World Development*, 88, 122–133. DOI: 10.1016/j.worlddev.2016.07.017
- Falco C., Rotondi V. (2016). Political Islam, Internet Use and Willingness to Migrate: evidence from the Arab Barometer. *Peace Economics, Peace Science and Public Policy*, 22(1), 73–95. DOI: 10.1515/peps-2015-0045
- Falco C., Gobel K. (2015). Does the desire to remit foster integration? Evidence from migrants in Spain. *Economics Letters*, 137, 131–134. DOI: 10.1016/j.econlet.2015.10.013

Working Papers & Forthcoming

- Corbi R., Falco C., Uberti L. (2026). Dams and Rural Conflict: Evidence from Brazil's Hydropower Expansion. *FEEM Working Paper* 01.2026, ISSN: 2037-1209. SSRN: dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6075206

- Bertocchi G., Dimico A., Falco C. (2024). Family planning and ethnic heritage: evidence from Sub-Saharan Africa. CEPR-DP 19665; EIEF Working Paper 24/11; GLO Discussion Paper No. 1511; IZA DP No. 17391; RECent WP 157

Work in Progress

- Climate adaptation in agriculture and cultural persistence: effects on women's labour force participation (2026). With Raimondi V., Nota P.

Other Publications

- *Equilibri Magazine* (2026): 'Energy, dams and local conflicts in Brazil' [editorial].
- CRC Group (2015–2018): 'The conditions of poor children and adolescents', in *Children's and adolescents' rights in Italy*. 7th, 8th, and 9th update reports monitoring the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child in Italy.

PARTICIPATION IN INTERNATIONAL RESEARCH PROJECTS

PNRR — ONFOODS Project (code PE00000003) 2023 – 2026

Role: Research Associate and Principal Investigator ('WATERMAN')

- Empirical analyses of trade policies, institutional settings, and environmental constraints shaping agri-food systems and rural territories, using econometric and spatial methods.
- As PI of 'WATERMAN': promoted and coordinated cross-spoke scientific collaboration aimed at studying interactions between food systems, environmental change, and large infrastructure investments. Developed an original dataset on hydropower infrastructure in Brazil through systematic collection and harmonisation of project-level data, enabling accurate temporal identification of infrastructure shocks for causal analysis.

PRIN — The Economics of Culture (Grant 2017KHR4MB) 2021 – 2022

Role: Research Associate PI: Prof. G. Bertocchi

- Led the construction, cleaning, and harmonisation of a multi-country DHS microdata panel on ethnicity, gender, and reproductive outcomes across Sub-Saharan Africa, spanning several survey rounds and dozens of country files.
- Standardised variable coding and indicator definitions across DHS waves to ensure cross-national comparability, and integrated survey microdata with external ethnographic and geospatial datasets.
- Conducted empirical analysis of ethnic identity, gender, and family planning outcomes using the resulting harmonised dataset.

EU HORIZON 2020 — STRENGTH2FOOD (Grant N. 678024) 2016 – 2017

Role: Research Associate

- Investigated the effects of food quality policies (PDO and PGI schemes) on trade and agri-food system performance, covering intra-EU and extra-EU trade. Conducted quantitative and econometric analyses to evaluate the impact of quality schemes on exports, productive specialisation, and market integration.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Milan — MSc in Environmental and Food Economics

- Adjunct Professor: *Food Security and Rural Development* [taught in English] — A.Y. 2025–26
- Professor: *Food Security and Rural Development* [taught in English] — A.Y. 2024–25, 2023–24, 2018–19
- TA (exercise sessions & tutoring): *Food Chains in the Global Markets* [taught in English] — A.Y. 2017–18 and 2016–17

University of Milano-Bicocca — BSc in Organizational Sciences

- Adjunct Professor: *Economia Politica* — A.Y. 2021–22
- Adjunct Professor: *Economia Politica* and *Principles of Economics* — A.Y. 2022–23
- Adjunct Professor: *Macroeconomics* — A.Y. 2017–18 and 2016–17
- TA (tutoring): *Public Economics* — A.Y. 2013–14; *Introduction to Economics* — A.Y. 2012–13

Saint Paul University, Takeo Province, Cambodia 2012

- Professor of *Development Economics* [taught in English, 60 h] — BSc in Management. Initiator and coordinator of the cooperation agreement between the University of Milano-Bicocca and Saint Paul University for the delivery of the programme.

Thesis Supervision and Co-supervision

Advisor — MSc in Environmental and Food Economics, University of Milan

- 'Climate Change and Agri-Cultural Heritage: Evidence from Tanzania' — Candidate: Brizzolara Pietro. A.Y. 2024–25.
- 'Children's Malnutrition and Mother's Fertility: The Effects of Household Air Pollution in Sub-Saharan Africa' — Candidate: Coita Alessia. A.Y. 2023–24.

Co-advisor — MSc in Environmental and Food Economics, University of Milan

- 'Climate-induced mobility and gender inequality' — Candidate: Francolini Aurora. A.Y. 2025–26.
- 'Estimating CO2 emissions with farm-level data' — Candidate: Matichecchia Simone. A.Y. 2022–23.
- 'Migration and Global Warming: an empirical test exploiting EU asylum seekers' — Candidate: Borniotto Diana. A.Y. 2017–18.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE & FIELDWORK

Project Coordinator 2019 – 2021

Pontifical Institute for Foreign Missions, Brazil

- Coordination of social development projects and impact evaluation in Parelheiros and Grajaú (São Paulo): data analysis and monitoring of interventions targeting children, youth, and families in vulnerable contexts.
- Management of the full project cycle of 'Esporte na Quebrada' for child development in favelas, funded by Projeto Itaú–UNICEF, from implementation to final evaluation.

Researcher 2016 – 2017

Compagnia di San Paolo and Fondazione per la Scuola, Italy

- Research and analysis of administrative and statistical datasets (ISTAT, INVALSI, MIUR) supporting the evaluation of regional school systems. Drafting of institutional reports and collaboration with the Italian Ministry of Education (MIUR).

Project Coordinator (PI) — Fondazione Roberto Franceschi Grant (€10,000) 2015

Fondazione Roberto Franceschi, Italy

- Design and implementation of a lab-in-the-field experiment in Cambodia: research protocol, data collection strategy, training of local enumerators, digitisation and analysis of paper-based data. Results contributed to a publication in *Ecological Economics*.

Researcher 2014

Centro Studi Industria Leggera (CSIL), Italy

- Applied research in support of the European Commission: qualitative and quantitative sectoral analyses, policy briefs, and cost–benefit analysis on regional case studies (Apulia).

Researcher 2010 – 2011

Istituto per gli Studi di Politica Internazionale (ISPI), Italy

- Research and project coordination; Project Coordinator of 'L'Europa dei giovani Europei'. Support to climate change research: data analysis, literature review, and drafting of research and dissemination materials.

Project Coordinator 2012

Saint Paul University, Takeo Province, Cambodia

- Initiator and coordinator of the cooperation agreement between the University of Milano-Bicocca and Saint Paul University for the delivery of a Bachelor's degree programme in Development Economics.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS & SEMINARS

International and National Conferences (as presenter)

2026

- 'Climate adaptation in agriculture and cultural persistence: effects on women's labour force participation' — AIEAA Annual Conference, Rome (Italy), 10–12 June 2026
- 'Climate adaptation in agriculture and cultural persistence: effects on women's labour force participation' — AES Annual Conference, Oxford (UK), 23–25 March 2026

2025

- 'The Hidden Cost of Large Infrastructure: Hydropower-Induced Deforestation in Brazil' — EAAE Conference *Food System Transformation in Challenging Times*, Bonn (DE), 28–30 August 2025
- 'The Hidden Cost of Large Infrastructure: Hydropower-Induced Deforestation in Brazil' — AES Annual Conference, Bordeaux (FR), 14–15 April 2025

2024

- 'The environmental bias of trade policy through the virtual water content of agri-food products' — AES Annual Conference, Edinburgh (UK), 19–20 March 2024
- 'The environmental bias of trade policy through the virtual water content of agri-food products' — AIEAA Conference *The Social Sustainability of European Agriculture Facing Old and New Challenges*, Bari (IT), 20–21 June 2024

2023

- 'Evaluating Socio-Economic Impacts of GIs on Rural Areas' — EAAE Conference *Agri-food Systems in a Changing World: Connecting Science and Society*, Rennes (FR), 29 August – 2 September 2023
- 'Evaluating Socio-Economic Impacts of GIs on Rural Areas' — AIEAA Conference *Guns, Germs and Climate: Food Security and Food Systems in a Risky World*, Milan (IT), 22–23 June 2023

2022

- 'Natural Disasters and Preferences for the Environment: Evidence from the Impressionable Years' — BoMoPaV Economics Conference, Rimini (IT), 1 July 2022

2017

- 'Climate change and migration: is agriculture the main channel?' — EAAE Conference *Towards Sustainable Agri-Food Systems: Balancing Between Markets and Society*, Parma (IT), 29 August – 1 September 2017
- 'Climate change and migration: is agriculture the main channel?' — AIEAA Conference *Economics and Politics of Migration: Implications for Agriculture and Food*, Piacenza (IT), 15–16 June 2017

2016

- 'Estimating the trade effects of the EU food quality policy' — EAAE Seminar *Structural Change in Agri-food Chains*, Rennes (FR), 27–28 October 2016

- ‘Estimating the trade effects of the EU food quality policy’ — AIEAA Conference *The Changing Role of Regulation in the Bio-based Economy*, Bologna (IT), 16–17 June 2016
- ‘The less extreme, the more you leave: radical Islam and willingness to migrate’ — SITES-IDEAS Conference *Models and Policies for Human Development and Sustainable Growth*, Florence (IT), 29–30 September 2016

Workshops (as presenter)

2024

- ‘Family Planning and Ethnic Heritage: Evidence from Sub-Saharan Africa’ — PRIN Workshop, University of Modena and Reggio Emilia (IT), 12–13 December 2024
- ‘Dams and Social Conflict: Evidence from Brazil’ — Departmental seminar, University of Milan (IT), 25 October 2024
- ‘Trade policy and virtual water: does country water insecurity matter?’ — ONFOODS Workshop *Sustainable Food Chains*, Parma (IT), 11–12 April 2024

2022

- ‘Natural Disasters and Preferences for the Environment’ — Departmental seminar, University of Modena and Reggio Emilia (IT)

2020

- ‘Natural Disasters and Preferences for the Environment’ — Departmental seminar, University of São Paulo, Brazil

2014

- ‘The less extreme, the more you leave: radical Islam and willingness to migrate’ — CIdE Workshop *Econometrics and Empirical Economics*, Perugia (IT)

2013–2015

- Internal departmental seminars — University of Milano-Bicocca and Università Cattolica del Sacro Cuore, Milan (IT)

Conferences and Workshops with Co-authored Presentations (without personal attendance)

2025

- ‘Family Planning and Ethnic Heritage: Evidence from Sub-Saharan Africa’ — University of Groningen (NL), September 2025
- ‘Family Planning and Ethnic Heritage: Evidence from Sub-Saharan Africa’ — Society for the Advancement of Economic Theory Conference, Ischia (IT), July 2025
- ‘Family Planning and Ethnic Heritage: Evidence from Sub-Saharan Africa’ — World Economic History Congress, Lund (SE), 28 July – 1 August 2025
- ‘Family Planning and Ethnic Heritage: Evidence from Sub-Saharan Africa’ — Thema Gender, Inheritance and Fertility Workshop, CY Cergy (FR), 19 December 2025

2024

- ‘Family Planning and Ethnic Heritage: Evidence from Sub-Saharan Africa’ — EUI Gender and Politics Working Group, Florence (IT), November 2024
- ‘Family Planning and Ethnic Heritage: Evidence from Sub-Saharan Africa’ — CEPR Conference *Economic Development and Structural Change: A Conference in Honour of W. Arthur Lewis*, Manchester (UK), 13–14 November 2024

2023

- ‘Family Planning and Ethnic Heritage: Evidence from Sub-Saharan Africa’ — Workshop on Fertility, Health, and Human Capital, Belfast (UK), 8–9 June 2023

- ‘Family Planning and Ethnic Heritage: Evidence from Sub-Saharan Africa’ — Royal Economic Society Diversity and Human Capital Workshop: Gender, Exeter (UK), 12–13 June 2023

2022

- ‘Family Planning and Ethnic Heritage: Evidence from Sub-Saharan Africa’ — University of Florida, Departmental Seminar (US), December 2022

Awards & Honours

- Post-doctoral Research Fellowship (3 years) — CAPES, Ministry of Education, Brazil (2019–2021)
- Research Funding Grant (€10,000) — Fondazione Roberto Franceschi, Italy (2015–2016)
- Merit-based PhD Scholarship (3 years) — Italian Ministry of Education and University of Milano-Bicocca (2011–2015)
- Erasmus Scholarship — EU Project (2007)

Scientific Society Memberships

- Italian–Brazilian Association of Economics (AIBE), *Board Member*, since 2024 and *President* since 2025
- Italian Association of Agricultural Applied Economics (AIEAA), since 2016
- European Association of Agricultural Economists (EAAE), since 2016
- Agricultural Economic Society (AES), since 2024

Languages & Technical Skills

Language Skills

Language	Listening/Reading	Speaking	Writing
English	C1	C2	C2
Portuguese	C1	C2	C2
Spanish	B1	B1	B1

Technical Skills

- Statistical and econometric software: Stata, R
- Geospatial analysis: ArcGIS

Institutional & Outreach Activities

- **Board Member, New Humanity International Foundation** (since December 2025): contributed to drafting an AICS-funded project proposal for a rural development and disability inclusion project in Cameroon.
- **International mission to Tanzania** (June 2025): hosted by the University of Iringa to support the launch of a BSc in Agricultural Economics, including coordination, curriculum design support, and collaboration with local faculty.
- **Public outreach seminar series** ‘Population, Development and Migration’ (6 hours, April 2024): delivered at the University of Pavia to MSc students in African and Asian Studies.
- **Member of the Departmental Communication Committee** (since 2024): supports dissemination of the Department’s scientific and educational initiatives, contributing to outreach strategies and communication of environmental-related content.

- **Co-organiser, 'Early Career Research Seminars'** (since 2025): promotes research dissemination by early-career scholars and fosters academic exchange within the Department of Environmental Science and Policy, University of Milan.

Main Research Themes

Climate Adaptation, Rural Livelihoods, and Gender

This line of research studies how rural households and labour markets adapt to climate change, and how that capacity to adapt is itself a development outcome shaped by history and culture. Combining individual-level microdata on women's occupational trajectories with high-resolution climate indicators and ethnographic measures of agricultural and pastoral heritage (*agri-cultural heritage*), the research shows that climate adaptation is not a uniform process but depends on socially and historically determined adaptive capacities. It examines short- and long-run adaptation channels in rural labour markets along two dimensions: (i) a gender dimension, assessing whether women and men face different constraints and opportunities in adjusting their livelihoods; and (ii) a spatial dimension, linking climate shocks to land use and the reorganisation of agricultural activity. The aim is to inform climate and social policy that is sensitive to cultural and institutional heterogeneity in developing economies.

Large Infrastructure, Sustainability Governance, and Local Development

This line of research studies how large energy infrastructure reshapes local development trajectories and what it reveals about the governance of sustainability transitions, using hydropower dam expansion in Brazil as a setting. Integrating administrative data, high-resolution land use indicators, and spatial econometric methods, the research documents how dam construction triggers structural change in local economies — through transport infrastructure expansion, agricultural intensification, and deforestation — with effects that vary by territorial and institutional context. Building on an original dam-level dataset reconstructing the temporal phases of project implementation, ongoing work extends the analysis to the social dimensions of infrastructure shocks, examining how changes in land use and resource access translate into shifts in conflict, demographic behaviour, and women's economic opportunities. The broader aim is to identify the institutional and governance conditions under which infrastructure-driven energy transitions generate equitable and sustainable territorial outcomes.